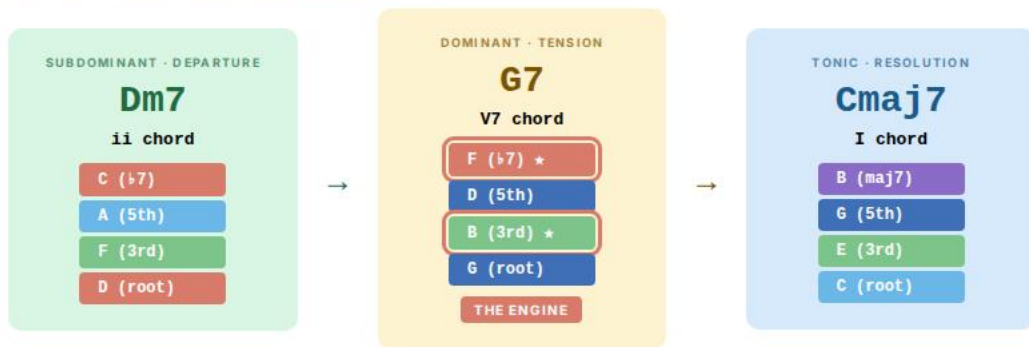


THE II-V-I EXPLAINED

The most fundamental harmonic progression in Western music — and why the tritone inside the V7 chord is the engine that makes everything work.

Dm7 – G7 – Cmaj7 — THREE FUNCTIONS, ONE JOURNEY



VOICE LEADING — THE TRITONE COLLAPSES INWARD BY HALF STEPS

B (3rd of G7)
 ↑ rises ½ step
 C (root of Cmaj7)
Leading tone rises to tonic

F (♭7 of G7)
 ↓ falls ½ step
 E (3rd of Cmaj7)
♭7 resolves to major 3rd

IN MINOR KEYS — B♭7 → E7 → A♭7

B♭7

→

E7

→

A♭7

The V chord (E7) stays MAJOR even in minor context — this is critical. The major 3rd (G♯) provides the leading tone that pulls up to A, the root of A♭7. Without the raised 7th (G♯ from harmonic minor), the resolution loses its pull.

"The ii-V-I is the engine. Everything else is decoration, extension, or variation. Master this one motion and you understand the engine behind 95% of Western harmony."